

THE
Elder Son Explained
AND THE
ROMISH CHURCH
EXPOSED

by
John Church

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SON EXPLAINED, AND THE ROMISH CHURCH EXPOSED *****

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THE
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ROMISH CHURCH EXPOSED.

Eight reasons why I believe that he was not a saved Character,

VARIOUS have been the opinions of good men concerning the elder son: some suppose it must mean the elect angels, who, though holy beings, yet were envious of the high honors conferred on man who was so far beneath them. He took not on him the nature of angels, but, as the son of God, he took on him the seed of Abraham; and being found in fashion as a man, he humbled himself to the death of the cross. But to form such an opinion of the holy angels is quite absurd, seeing, that so far from envying what grace has done for fallen man, they are represented as filled with joy. Hence the prophet calls upon them to rejoice—"Sing, O ye heavens! the Lord hath redeemed his people"—and in their death and safe arrival to glory, the promise runs—"For ye shall go out with joy and be led forth with peace, the mountains and the hills shall break forth into singing, (the elect angels and the spirits of just men made perfect) and all the trees shall clap their hands for joy"—God's called people upon the conversion and happy death of others—how vast their joy at the incarnation of Christ, when they brought glad tidings of great joy; and after delivering the glorious message, they returned singing glory to God in the highest. Our dear Lord also assures us there is joy in the presence of the angels when sinners on earth repent. And why? As Mr. Toplady says, "Tell me ye seraphs of light, tell me ye souls of just men made perfect, why this exuberance of holy rapture on the real recovery of a single sinner to God?" Because ye know, assuredly, that every true conversion is, first, a certain proof that the person converted is one of your own elect number; and secondly, that he shall infallibly

persevere and be brought to heaven. Many more reasons might be assigned why the elect angels rejoice in the conversion of a sinner to God. Other writers have supposed that our Lord did not mean any particular person or character, or order of beings, by the elder brother in this parable; but this is most absurd, to suppose that our Lord should utter so many words, including eight verses, *about nobody*. If the younger brother alludes to some order of beings, surely the description of the elder brother cannot be without meaning. This however was the opinion of the late worthy John Bradford; but he is the only writer I hope that ever held such a weak idea. Others have supposed, that the elder brother signifies a believer truly converted, but very legal in mind—one that has been kept from outward sin—very precise and moral—virtuous and consistent, yet envious at the conduct of God our heavenly Father towards a most desperate backslider. This I acknowledge was my opinion for some years; but in time I was led to see that this opinion was wrong, and that the prodigal son refers to the state of God's elect as fallen in Adam the first, and called, convinced, and effectually converted in Adam the second, by the Holy Spirit; and that the elder brother is an exhibition of the whole group of pharisees in every age and of every denomination. For however moral a believer may be kept all his days, yet was there ever, is there now living, one child of God upon earth that ever could use such language as this proud boaster is represented using. "Lo, take notice Lord, these many years have I served thee—I never transgressed thy commandment AT ANY TIME." I say again, there NEVER was such a believer to be found that dare to make use of such arrogance and awful lies. None but the God-man Mediator has a right to such language—He never transgressed the commandments of God at any time, but fulfilled all righteousness for the justification of his church, which is the best and first robe that clothed the repenting prodigal. The saints of God, as recorded in the word of God, have at times made use of very passionate language under pinching trials, and when falsely accused have vindicated themselves from cruel aspersions; they have also appealed to God of the sincerity of the heart, made so by grace; but all boasting is for ever excluded in the religion of free grace. God has declared the lofty looks of man shall be humbled, and the haughtiness of man shall be brought low, and the Lord alone shall be exalted. This must be the case with every man in this world, or else where God is he never can come: except a man be born again he cannot enter into the kingdom of God, neither the liberty of

the gospel here, nor the mysteries of grace, nor eternal glory. It is very evident that this poor creature, bragging and boasting of his goodness, never had been through the needle's-eye of regeneration—that camel had never been reduced small enough for that, and of course unfit for communion with God upon earth or in heaven. I beg my reader will once more attentively read the Saviour's account of this ambitious, arrogant, envious, lying, ignorant, self-righteous boaster.

Luke xxv. ver. 25 to the end.—Now his elder son was in the field: and as he came and drew nigh to the house, he heard music and dancing. And he called one of the servants, and asked what these things meant. And he said unto him, thy brother is come; and thy father hath killed the fatted calf, because he hath received him safe and sound. And he was angry, and would not go in: therefore came his father out, and intreated him. And he answering said to his father, Lo, these many years do I serve thee, neither transgressed I at any time thy commandment: and yet thou never gavest me a kid, that I might make merry with my friends: But as soon as this thy son was come, which hath devoured thy living with harlots, thou hast killed for him the fatted calf. And he said unto him, Son, thou art ever with me, and all that I have is thine. It was meet that we should make merry, and be glad: for this thy brother was dead, and is alive again; and was lost, and is found.

Upon the serious attentive reading of these words, who can doubt that it is an highly-finished portrait of a pharisee's heart and conduct. This I believe is the general opinion of the most sound divines; but the very best treatise I ever met with was written by Mr. David Fenner, of the Albany Road, Camberwell. After I had been through several lectures upon the subject of these brothers, I was afterwards much pleased, satisfied, instructed and confirmed by reading that treatise; and my reader will see the reasons why these best of writers consider the elder brother a rigid pharisee.

1st.—His situation: he was in the field, not in the spiritual church of God, but in the same place the poor prodigal was when he was sent to feed swine, working at the law with the rest of the swinish multitude, who can feed upon nothing else but their own fancied goodness; but whether they made a

parson of him to feed the rest with such rubbish as is the case now aday, I cannot tell.

2nd.—The awful falsehood, “I never transgressed thy commandment at any time.” This is giving the lie to God’s word, which reveals the sinful state and wretched depravity of every man in heart, lip, and life. Everyman by nature is a God-hater—his carnal mind is enmity against God. There is not a grace-taught person in this world that ever dare to use such arrogant lying language.

3rd.—His boasting and impudent demand of God’s attention to his service —“Lo, take notice how many years I have served thee.”—An awful proof he had never been in the stripping room—in the element of free grace all boasting is excluded. But this is not the only place where the Saviour has exposed such PROUD BOASTERS. Many will say to me in that day, Lord, Lord, have we not prophesied, preached in thy name, and in thy name done many wonderful works as the ground of our acceptance? Mind, the Saviour does not say they did so, but this is their plea and boast. So also the pharisee that went up into the temple to pray; (Luke xviii) but there is not a word of prayer in all he said—but with a heart full of pride and a mouth full of lies he arrogantly addressed God—at the same time told seven lies in his presence.

4th.—His murmuring: “Thou never gave me a kid”—that is, not the smallest remuneration for his long services. Here the pride of the heart is awfully manifested—wanting to bring in God a debtor to him for his paltry, ragged, rotten, worm-eaten cobweb righteousness. The grand design of grace is to humble the heart, and to cause us gratefully to acknowledge that all we have and all we are out of hell is favor and mercy indeed.

5.—His rebellion: “The father went out and intreated him, but he was angry and would not come in.” This refers to the ministry of the gospel and its external call, The Jews were first favored with it; but in the pride of their heart, they rejected it, and their ecclesiastical rulers would neither go into a profession of the Messiah nor let others, without much opposition; and so it is to this day in some places where the doctrine of free grace is preached. Pharisee preachers and people are angry at the doctrine; they will neither hear it themselves, though intreated to listen to sterling truth, but they

persecute those that receive it; they have neither will nor desire—of course they have not the spirit of God who makes his people willing.

6th.—Notwithstanding his boasted perfection, holiness, morality, and long service, yet he was quite destitute of those things. The prodigal was blest with conviction of his danger, a deep sense of need, self despair, the spirit of power on his will, humble confession of sin, the spirit of adoption, the ring, the robe, the calf, the shoes, the music, and the holy company—he was a perfect stranger to these twelve blessings, that every believer, more or less, is led to enjoy.

7th.—His profound ignorance: he knew not what these things meant—a plain proof he had never been taught of God. The pharisees in our Lord's day used sometimes to call the disciples aside to ask the meaning of our Lord's words; and as they were present when the parables were delivered, this was aimed at them all the way through, under the figure of the elder son, and his boasting, pride, enmity and ignorance. To poor prodigals only it is given to know the mysteries of the kingdom, but to such vaunters as these, it is not given.

8th.—His hatred: he hated all that was blessed, the truths of the gospel, the glory of grace in its sovereignty, freeness and power. This earthly being could not bear to see a servant reigning—a fool filled with meat—the odious married, and become heir to the blessings of the covenant; he hated his brother, nor would he own him in any sense but with contempt. Says, thy son, not my brother—and he that hateth his brother is a murderer; and we know that no such murderer hath eternal life.

These are the reasons why I am of opinion that the elder brother described by our Lord refers to all self-righteous persons.

The objections in general to this opinion are, because God calls him his son: so did Abraham call Dives, even in hell—son, thou in thy life time receivedst thy good things, and this son calls the Messiah Father—send a drop of water. All mankind are called sons by creation—have we not all one father? Hath not one God created us? The angels by creation are called sons—professors who turned apostates before the flood are called sons—and the whole body of Israel God denominated his sons—so that in a national way and in the same profession of the Jewish religion, the most

precise and the most profane were brethren; but because some of the very worst amongst them were called by grace to the knowledge and profession of Christ, these angry brethren hated them and often disowned them.

Another objection has been raised from the language of the father—son, thou art ever with me; so, in general, are all SUCH sons—always religious—always in a bustle about religion, though strangers to the power of it. The pharisees were always either in the temple, or private houses, or public streets, at their devotions. As it regards the external of ceremonies, here they were always encompassing God’s altar, visiting God’s house, or reading God’s word and the traditions of the elders. They were always with God, but God was not with them, for he despised their offerings and services. Read Isaiah i. 11 to 15, and Matthew xxiii. will fully explain this. Another objection: “All that I have is thine.”—This must be limited to bare external things; for he was quite destitute of the favors granted to his brother; but all ordinances, institutions and temporal blessings in the land of Canaan they had; and even Christ and the gospel were sent them, but they never rested till they had murdered the son of God and turned the gospel out of doors. So to this day the majority of Pharisees are mere easy professors, and in general opulent characters, who have their portion amongst the smooth stones of the brook, whose belly thou fillest with thy hid treasures: for the earth he has given to the children of men.

Reader, what a mercy you are made to differ from such—OH, TO GRACE
HOW GREAT A DEBTOR.

While thousands are at present crying out for more liberty to the catholics, it is very evident that very few persons know any thing of their sentiments. I present you, therefore, with a small piece of them, published some years ago in the Gospel Magazine; which, after reading, I think no grace-taught person will ever be anxious to see them possess more liberty than they do; but, with one heart and one voice, exclaim, in reference to the defender of the faith of protestants—God save the King.

The following Catholic Creed was published at Cologne, in the year 1714. It serves, with very little alteration, for all apostates. Not many years ago, it was signed by the son of a very opulent Calvinist merchant of Cologne,

whom the monks of that city had made one of their proselytes. The reader will be astonished at the folly and blasphemy of its contents.

THE ROMAN CATHOLIC CREED.

I believe and confess, that, through the peculiar care of this Christian magistracy, and wise government of Cologne, and the active industry and assistance of the holy Augustin fathers, I have been entirely brought over from my heretical life and religion, to the true church of Rome, the only one in which salvation can be obtained; and I do publicly declare, to the whole world, that I embrace this faith freely and without compulsion.

“I confess and believe, that the Pope is Christ’s vicar, and has full power to forgive the sins of all mankind, according to his own will and pleasure, either to save, to let them perish, or to excommunicate them, if he thinks fit.

“I confess the Pope to be the supreme head of the church, and that he can never do wrong.

“I also confess, that whatever the Pope establishes, whether in the Holy Scriptures or not, whatever he shall please to ordain, is the truth, divine and genuine; that, consequently, every inferior person should esteem them equal to the commandments of God.

“I do confess, that the most holy Pope should be adored by every one, with divine honors, and that every one should bow the knee to him as to Christ himself.

“I confess and declare, that the Pope should be honored by all men, in all things, as the most holy father; and moreover, that those heretics who live contrary to his ordinances, should not only be exterminated BY FIRE and SWORD, without exception, and without the least mercy, but also that their bodies and souls should be delivered up to Satan.

“I confess, that the reading of the Holy Scriptures is the source of all sects and parties, as also absolute blasphemy.

“I confess, that to invoke the saints, worship the holy father, and bow the knee to them, make pilgrimages to their tombs, clothe them, and burn lights before them, is godly, holy and useful.

“I confess, that a priest is much greater than the mother of God: Mary only bore the Lord Christ, and never conceived again; but a Romish priest offers, and forms the Lord Christ, not only as often as he wishes, but in any manner he pleases; yea, he feeds upon him while he chews his bread.

“I confess, that it is proper to read masses, to give alms, and to pray for the dead.

“I confess, that the Pope of Rome has power to alter the Holy Scripture, to augment or diminish it, according to his own pleasure.

“I confess, that the soul will be purified by purgatory after death, and that its deliverance from thence is partly effected by the sacrifice of the mass offered up by the priest.

“I acknowledge, that to receive the holy eucharist in one kind, is good and salutary; but, to receive it in both kinds, is heretical and damnable.

“I acknowledge, that those who receive the holy communion in one kind, enjoy and eat the whole of Christ, both body and blood, and also his godhead and his bones.

“I acknowledge, that there are seven true and effectual sacraments.

“I acknowledge, that God is honored by representations of him, and may, by means of them, be known of men.

“I acknowledge, that the Holy Virgin Mary is queen of heaven, and governs, together with the Son; and that, according to her will, the Son is obliged to act in all things.

“I acknowledge, that the Holy Virgin Mary should be esteemed, both by men and angels, higher than Christ, the Son of God himself.

“I acknowledge, that the bones of the saints are possessed of great virtues, on which account they ought to be honored by men, and have chapels built for them.

“I acknowledge, that the Roman Catholic faith is unadulterated, godly, saving, and true; but that the Protestant, which I, of my own accord, have abjured, is false, erroneous, blasphemous, accursed, heretical, hurtful; that the Protestant religion is seditious, abominable, forged and devised. Since the Roman Catholic religion is, therefore, throughout, good and salutary, I curse all those who taught me these abominable heresies in both kinds; I curse my parents who educated me in the heretical faith; and, I also curse those who made the Roman Catholic faith so dubious and suspicious to me, as well as those who gave me to drink of the accursed cup; yes, I curse myself, and think myself accursed, because I made myself a partaker of this accursed heretical cup, ^[11] of which it did not become me to drink.

“I acknowledge that the Holy Scripture is imperfect, and is a dead letter, as long as it is not explained by the Pope of Rome; and that the common people ought not to be allowed to read it.

“I acknowledge, that a requiem, sung by a Romish priest, is more useful than a hundred sermons; and, on that account, I curse all those books which I have read, in which that heretical and blasphemous doctrine is contained; I also curse all the works which I read whilst I lived in this heretical faith.

“All this I do, with a sincere mind, confirm, as a public retraction of the heretical doctrine, in the presence of the reverend father W. and the other fathers of the convent of — and to the whole Roman Catholic church, male and female, that in these, and similar articles, is the true church.

“Moreover, I promise, that I will never more, through my whole life, return to this heretical doctrine of the sacrament in both kinds, although it should be allowable to do so. I also promise, that as long as I have a drop of blood in my body, I will not educate any child of mine in that accursed faith, nor will I consent he or she should be brought up therein by others, which I herewith promise.

“I also swear, that I will help to persecute this accursed heretical doctrine, secretly and openly, with words and works, the sword even not excepted.

“Lastly, I swear before God, the angels, and before all the congregation present, that if any alteration should take place either in church or state, I never will become an apostate from the Roman Catholic and godly church,

either through fear or favor, and return again to this accursed heresy, nor will I receive the same.

“As a confirmation of my oath, I at the same time receive the holy communion: and I cause also this, my confession, written and subscribed with my own hand, to be made public in print, and the original thereof to be preserved in the holy archives of the church of —.” [Rather, synagogue of Satan.]

Should all the forms which men devise
Assault my faith with treach'rous art,
I'd call them vanity and lies,
And bind the Gospel to my heart.

FINIS.

R. WESTON, Printer,
Crosby-row, Southwark.

FOOTNOTES.

[\[11\]](#) Wine at the Sacrament, which is forbid the people.

*** END OF THE PROJECT GUTENBERG EBOOK THE ELDER SON
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